# Technically, A Reunion

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30488217.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Entrapta & Scorpia (She-Ra)

**Characters:**
Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit

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by 4theHonourofGräysküll (AVAwolfpack), But_Its_For_Science (DakianDelomast), DakianDelomast

Summary

In the wake of the Battle for the Heart, Etheria has been healing and the explosive florification event has been cleaned up. With that completed, The Best Friends Squad is making good on their promise to bring back magic to the universe. Unfortunately they only have one interstellar craft and it refuses to leave without her chief mechanic, Entrapta. She hasn't been seen or spoken with since she departed to Beast Island with Hordak. With that conundrum, Scorpia has taken it upon herself to reach out to her friend. A reunion of the Super Pal Trio is long overdue.

But the Entrapta that arrives is not the same one that they last saw. And this seems to be more than something just a hug can fix. But maybe a friend can.

Notes

Hello everyone and Welcome to our first interlude! Scorpia's doing the best she can with what she's got. But the rest is going to be up to Entrapta to sort out in their adventures in space in her story Our Fires Within An Error Trap. This is a brief scene before the Best Friends Squad took off on their adventure into SPACE. These interludes set up the main story we have going on in the parts. We'll also be including them in the prologue in case people want to start there.

Enjoy the read, and be sure to tune in to Entrapta's fic. I promise you it's a ride you're not going to forget. ^_^ - Dakian

*Hey Entrapta! It's been a while. Well maybe. I don't know if you've been getting my video or my voice messages, or my pictures come to think of it. I thought maybe a text message would be good to send, too! It took me a while to write it until Catra agreed to help me so she's typing this right now! These are her fingers typing this. Oh, she's groaning right now. She's angry I'm making her write everything, but I don't want to miss any of this.*

*Anyway, things have been great in Bright Moon and Plumeria. We've managed to clear up most of the 'explosive florification' as you coined it. Well, except for Plumeria, we actually have tree skyscrapers! They're so big and tall.*

*Oh, Catra has just reminded me why we are sending this! See, Glimmer, Bow, Catra, Adora, and Micah are all preparing Darla for a new adventure! They figure there's bound to be planets that need the same kind of She-Ra magic and maybe they can start helping them. We actually got a call from the Star Siblings. They said you met them!*

*Sorry, sorry, you're right, Catra.*

*The important thing is that Darla has said she won't leave without you. So they're stuck unless you can get here. You must be really busy on Beast Island since you haven't been able to respond. Did the florification get there too? Must be a mess to clean up with the bots and whatnot. Adora says most of the scary things they told us in the Horde don't exist, but the pookas were pretty scary. They sound cute to me, but Bow insists they aren't. Maybe they're helpful now? You know, I just don't quite know.*

*Right, okay, sorry staying on track. We need you back here and we all would love to see you again. It's been so long and we need to catch up! I've been working on these plant machine things with Perfuma. Well, they're more like plants. But they grow stuff and they have these flowers that look like tiny gears and I want to show you!*

*Let me know if you get this!*

*Hope to see you soon!*

*-Scorpia & Catra*

*PS: Can you bring Emily, too? I really miss her.*

*PPS: Catra is saying this is the worst text letter ever. I disagree. And I'm making her type that.*

---

*Scorpia, I have received your letter and found it quite satisfactory in communicating the status of Bright Moon. I understand that Darla would not leave without me as I have extensive technical knowledge of her operations. I will see what I can do to convince her to depart, but I am afraid I must return to Beast Island afterwards. Please send a nautical vessel to meet me.*

*-Entrapta*

---

"That was all she sent back?" Adora peers over my arm to look at the pad.

"Yup, but at least we get to see her again." A crest of a wave breaks on the dock of Seaworthy and scatters the briny mist at us.

Catra swipes her hand in front of her face with a sneer. "I don't see why we had to wait out here."

Adora raises a dubious eyebrow. "Maybe you shouldn't have gotten us kicked out of the tavern then."

"You're just mad you lost that arm wrestling match."

"I *did not* . I got distracted when *you* tried to—"

“Isn’t this view amazing, guys?” I place a pincer on my hip and gesture outward with the other.

The ferruginous cliffs of Seaworthy rise behind us, descending down into open ocean. New ports have been carved into the rock wall, fresh wooden docks springing forth from the cliff-face. The protected entrance sheltered the inner city from an onslaught of waves in the winter months, but the destruction of Horde Prime necessitated some changes to the city. Open docks would be fine in the summer.

I side-eye Catra. She still wasn’t wearing the jacket. I wonder why? She acted like it meant everything to her. But I suppose that’s enough. Catra’s gonna Catra.

Melog’s tail gently thumps on the wooden dock. They look between us, blue glowing eyes full of concern, only to be interrupted by a spray provoking the most cutest and precious sneeze I have ever heard.

I nearly melt. “Awww! You sound just like Catra!” I hold my pincers in front of my face.

“They do *not* .” Catra huffs and crosses her arms.

Melog looks at me, startled. I resist the temptation to scoop them up into another hug. There’s serious business to be attended to. And I need to attempt to be professional. In some way, at least.

The docks teem with life around us. People move cargo from ship to ship. More goods needed moved more quickly. Glimmer’s kingdom was at the forefront of rescue and relocation to people displaced by the invasion. The Horde had scoured some of the smaller towns and cities off Etheria. Despite everything though, there is raucous joy all around us. Spirits are high after the clearing of the seaweed that had briefly overtaken their livelihoods. Now the seas are free again, and we could resume

moving supplies across the world and helping those that are still isolated.

I take in a deep breath. “It’s so gosh darn nice having the two of you here.”

“And me!” Swift Wind adds from behind us.

Melog mews as well.

“Yes! You guys, too! I always knew we’d be standing here together. I mean maybe not Melog—I didn’t even know there *was* a Melog. But I sure am glad that we’re here together, finally. I mean maybe not here, specifically. I wasn’t picturing Seaworthy, but you know, somewhere. The togetherness part is really what I was picturing.”

“Yeah. I guess it is.” Adora smirks at me, and nudges Catra prompting a rueful grin.

I resist another temptation to snatch everyone up in a giant hug. “When the biggest problem we have is doing a little gardening, I think things are pretty A-OK!” For us anyway. I missed talking with Entrapta. Even if I didn’t understand all the science thingies, her enthusiasm for her work made it hard not to be happy when she was around. I didn’t really get a chance to see her after the battle at the Heart. With Hordak back, she hadn’t really had time for anyone else and soon they left for Beast Island to get to work.

I only had a short goodbye with her. But that’s okay. We were all so busy cleaning up Etheria, it was easy to let those things slip by. I’m just glad I could see her again now.

A sail crests the horizon. The purple radiance is unmistakable of a Salineas skimmer. I point with my pincer. “There they are!”

“Okay, you’ve said that a dozen times already, Scorpia.” Catra huffs, ear flicking in annoyance. She’s edged behind me and Adora to block the incoming spray from the waves.

"Yes, but I mean it this time! I recognize that sail! Kinda—I think." I was sure of it. In fact, only one sail looks like his. The rainbow of light is visible even from this far away. Mermista's ship-builders had taken a special craft to his vessel. "It looks different though." The triangular sails are more squared now. The profile is lower to the water.

Adora shields her eyes with her hand, squinting at the ship. "I wonder what the Dragon's Daughter count is up to now."

"Oh, oh! I'm guessing eight!"

She turns to me in shock. "Eight?"

I nod solemnly. "He lost a few during the invasion."

Swift Wind pushes his head between us. "I don't understand the point of ships. Why don't people just fly everywhere? It's much more fun."

"Because not everyone has wings, idiot." Catra steps aside to let him through.

Her attitude is strange. She's been happy since the first couple nights back on Etheria—well, Catra happy. But now something feels different. Ever since she read Entrapta's response, her mood has soured. She sure has been in an *extra* bad mood all day today. Maybe I can get her something nice at one of the merchants before we leave.

The skimmer glides through the azure water, cutting through the waves like a scalpel. On the bow of the ship, a very excited Sea Hawk waves. "Hello, friends!" He still wears his blue jacket and bright crimson bandana. His mustache is impeccably groomed as always, but his headband is a turquoise—the royal color of Salineas.

I wave back. "Hello, Captain Sea Hawk!"

"Don't call him that," Catra says.

"Why not?"

The boat stops with a thud as it collides with the dock, causing Catra and Melog to leap into the air. I resist the urge to catch her. Sea Hawk barely maintains his balance grabbing onto the bowspirit and dangling about the docks. He clambors back up.

" *That's* why," Catra grumbles under her breath. She smooths out the poofed hair on her head and tail and shoots Sea Hawk a sharp glare. "You know you should've been steering."

"And miss my dramatic entrance? Never!" He fixes his jacket and takes a dramatic pose, setting his boot on the bow, finger pointing in the air. "It was a daring adventure, but I have recovered our friend Entrapta from the perilous Beast Island!"

I hold my pincers nervously in front of my face. "There're still mean things wandering around on it?"

"No, it's quite nice actually." His pose dips briefly before he puffs his chest out. "Regardless! I shall return!"

"Well, good to see he hasn't changed a bit," Adora says under her breath.

"I know! Isn't it wonderful?" I click my pincers in excitement.

There's a shifting and scuffling on the deck of the boat just out of our sight. A large plank lifts into the sky and falls with a clatter onto the wooden dock. Sea Hawk stands at the side and bows, gesturing someone onward.

The dome of a spherical robot crests the rise and comes lumbering down the ramp. The wood groans in protest as Emily rolls the rest of the way to us. I catch her in my wide open arms. "Emily!"

She chitters with a chorus of chirping and beeping joy. She stands on her legs again and pushes into me. She looks a little different. Her face still bears the scratch marks from so long ago.

Entrapta never wanted to fix those. Otherwise, she seems no worse for wear other than a dent on the top of her head. Must be tricky on Beast Island. If the stories I heard in the Horde were anything to go by...

"Hey, buddy! I missed you, too!" I pat the dome of her head and catch a smile from Catra out of my periphery before she straightens again and the expression falls from her face.

I follow her eyes to the deck of the ship.

The lilac pigtails rise first, then we see her face.

Something's wrong.

Maybe it's the long stare of emotionless eyes. Or the way she clutches her data terminal against her chest. Her muscles are taught, steps tentative, and her animate pigtails are as still as limp noodles. She slowly walks down the ramp.

Something is very wrong.

Melog mews softly, nudging Catra's leg.

"What's going on?" Swift Wind whispers, his head dipped toward Adora's ear.

"Maybe she's sea sick," she whispers back.

Emily turns back towards Entrapta and chitters. Entrapta smiles faintly.

"Hello, friends. It is good to… see you." Her reserved smile hurts more, somehow. Her pigtails hang limp beside her. All of the spark and joy has evaporated from her like… like a science thing. Like a cold cup of tea! Maybe I should say that. No, that'd be rude.

I pat Emily on the head. "Are you feeling okay, Entrapta?"

“Yes, the voyage was rather… long. Thank you sea-man for bringing tiny fish to eat.” She turns to Sea Hawk with a wan smile.

“It’s—ah, nevermind.” He coughs and smiles brightly. “It was my pleasure. I am sorry that our journey was not full of *ADVENTURE* !” He sweeps his arm broadly back toward his vessel. “I am honored to have you aboard the maiden voyager of the Dragon’s Daughter *X* !”

Adora snorts. “What happened to eight and nine?”

“Alas, the Dragon’s Daughter VIII met her end with a great sea dragon released from the depths in the explosive florification event of She-Ra. She was such a fine vessel.” He dramatically closes his fist in front of him and looks down. His grandeur is impeccable.

Catra glances at Adora and then back at him, eyebrow raised. “And number nine?”

Sea Hawk’s grandiose posture deflates like air out of a balloon. “Mermista sank her”

“Doesn’t she usually make those for you?” I pat the top of Emily’s head as she pushes into me, still chittering but in a more forlorn tone.

“She does! But I asked the shipbuilders to put a figurehead of her on the bow. It was beautiful. So radiant in the sunsets of Etheria. But when she found out it was naked, all was lost in my lovely Mermista’s fury.” He slumps with arms drooping down as though he could sink into the dock.

There’s a snicker that wafts through the group, but I don’t hear Entrapta. Where did she go? A brief panic overcomes me. Had she fallen into the water? Can she swim? What if someone ran off with her? I blink and see her walking away from us with Melog in tow keeping pace with her. I see Adora spot her as well. She has the same concern, it seems.

"You should consider a horse for your next figurehead! What's more majestic than *this* ?" Swift Wind unfurls his brightly colored wings and tosses his head back so his flowing mane billowed in the wind. "And 'dragon's daughter' is a little… gauche, don't you think? Have you considered rebranding to—"

"Swift Wind, now's not the time! Just c'mon." Adora beckons him to follow her, nodding pointedly at Catra and me. "I'll go talk to her."

"Oh! Are we going to discuss the horse-friendly modifications I want to make to the ship? I have a lot of ideas that I would like to —" He trots after her, his enthusiastic voice fading behind the crashing of ocean waves and seagulls. They follow the lonely inventor shambling down the dock. Purple pigtails drape behind her. The workers moving their boxes between the different boats step carefully over her trailing hair.

Catra leans in, and Sea Hawk and I follow her lead. "Was she like this the whole way?"

"Indeed." He twirls his mustache thoughtfully. "I even offered a shanty about bots and she would not join me."

Catra snaps a glare at him. "Okay, the first mistake was the shanty."

"My shanties are known to lift anyone's spirits." He steps back in indignation. "They're world renown!"

"C'mon, Catra. I bet the one about the bots was really good!" I pat him on the back.

"Oh, it was!" He clears his throat and places his hand on his chest. "Ooooohhhhhhh, there once was a great bot that —"

The sharp sound of Catra extending her claws screeches the shanty to a halt. "Nope, not now. You keep going and I'll throw you off this dock."

He frowns and slowly drops his hand from his chest. “Some people just don’t appreciate good art.”

“Tell me about it! You know she won’t even let me demo any of my songs with her?”

Sea Hawk’s face is awash with sympathy for me. “Oh, that is a *crime* , Catra. Why would you—”

“Would you two idiots shut up?” she snarls at us.

Emily bumps into me again. I glance down at her and smile reassuringly. “Hey, it’s okay! We’re talking about her.”

She shoves and steps back. The three of us open our huddle to her. She pauses for a moment now that Catra has locked eyes with her sensor. She slowly moves again and gestures to her side, beeping rapidly. I’d gotten pretty good at interpreting her beeps, but I didn’t quite understand what she was trying to tell me now.

“You know, I don’t remember her leg sticking quite like that.” I touch a pincer to my lips, brow furrowing. “And that dent is new.”

There’s a threatening growl from Catra. Her voice is low and dangerous. “Was Hordak there when you picked her up?”

“No. Come to think of it, it was just her and that bo—” He stops when Emily’s optical sensor narrows at him. “I mean Emily.”

Emily’s dome dips, gesturing her gratitude.

“Right. Scorpia—” Catra snaps like the crack of a whip.

The bark of my name draws me back towards her. I recognize that look. The one of the Horde so long ago. I have a brief lapse of fear, but her expression is different. Determination, not anger. “Yeah?”

“She’s coming with us.”

“But her note said—”

“I know what her note said, and I don’t care. Something is going on.” She looks to the side, staring down some unknown threat.

Sea Hawk points his finger upward. “I do believe that she needs something to lift her spirits. If a shanty cannot do it, then perhaps an *adventure* in the open *space* ?” He jabs the sky to emphasize the epicness of his idea.

Catra pinches her nose. “Sure fine, whatever, but Scorpia you need to convince her to leave on Darla with us.”

I blink twice at her. “Me? Why me?”

She crosses her arms and looks at me sidelong. “Because you’re annoyingly persistent at getting people to like you and feel wanted.” She turns her glare out toward the ocean and grumbles almost as an afterthought, “Trust me, I know.”

“Oh… I… I don’t know.” There’s a rush of warmth in my cheeks.

“Nonsense, Scorpia!” Sea Hawk throws an arm over my shoulders, flexing an arm over his chest. “You are the perfect choice for this mission!”

Sea Hawk and Catra watch me expectantly. Something rises in my chest—they really had confidence in me, didn’t they?

“Can you do it?” Catra asks.

I salute her. I look down at Emily. Somehow despite having only three limbs and an orb for a body, she reflects her concern.

“You stay here buddy.” I pat her on the head again.

She looks down, a little diminished, but she doesn’t move when I turn away to jog off to Adora and Swift Wind who are walking

back. Entrapta sits on the dock behind them, still clutching her data terminal tight. Alone except for Melog who hasn't left her.

"What happened?" I ask.

"I don't know." Adora shakes her head and shrugs. "We tried talking to her."

"I even offered her carrots. They have *real* carrots here and she didn't want any." Swift Wind clicks a hoof for emphasis.

"If she doesn't want carrots then something must really be wrong." I scratch my chin with my pincer.

"She wanted to be left alone for a minute." Adora spares a look over her shoulder back at Entrapta. "I'm worried about her."

"Us too. Catra told me I need to convince her to go with you guys."

Adora blinks as she processes what I just said. She focuses again, the same determination I saw in Catra in her eyes. "Can you do it?"

"I don't think this will be solved with a hug, but I'll do my best." I hold my pincers up and shrug, but the gesture slips from me into a slump. They all had so much confidence in me. So much expectation. I just wasn't sure if I deserved any of it.

Adora places an affectionate hand on my shoulder and I feel my doubts slide away. "You got this, Scorpia."

I smile appreciatively. I *can* do this. I straighten my back and walk towards Entrapta with a long stride. My courage diminishes as I get closer. An aura of melancholy lingers around her. She sits on the dock, legs kicking over the water. She still clutches her data terminal in her lap, chin resting on the top.

Melog looks at me with eyes full of concern and turns back to Entrapta.

I walk up behind her. “Hey, Entrapta. You doing okay?”

“Yes, all functions are optimal. Why do you ask?” Each word sounds more robotic than a… a robot’s really.

“I dunno. Something seems wrong.” I slowly take a seat next to her, minding her long pigtails that rest on the dock around her. I curl my tail back away from the walking dock workers. Another accidental sting could cause quite a ruckus.

“I haven’t been able to detect any abnormalities.” Her words are far away—she might as well still be on Beast Island.

Maybe I can get through to her with something. “Oh, okay… well how great is it to have the Super Pal Trio back together, huh? I mean, you and Catra were on Darla together and all that and I was chipped for a bit and after that everyone’s been so busy but *now!* Oh-ho. Now we’re all together again. Isn’t that great?”

She stares unfocused off to the horizon. “It is nice to see familiar faces again. I believe it is a serotonin inducer that brings back nicer memories. How has D—”

Excellent! A connection! “Oh, I’ve been great! I’ve been with Perfuma in Plumeria helping out there. Before that, Bright Moon. I’ve just been helping out wherever I can! Now that there isn’t a Horde or a Rebellion anymore, I’m just kind of wherever anyone needs me.”

She strains a smile at me. “That is good to hear. I was inquiring about Darla’s operating status, though.”

There’s a cold flush down the back of my neck. This is going to be harder than I thought. “Oh, Darla! She’s good… I think… You know, I don’t really know? Bow and the others are the ones that have been working on her and coming up with all the plans. I just came along to see you!”

“I appreciate the thought. I was… hoping to see you. But… actually I did it for Emily.” She kicks her feet over the ocean. A

wave of water rushes in and splashes against the pilings below us.

I match her kicking with my feet. Another wash of mist bursts up towards us. "Well, whatever Emily needs. She looks just great you know! Does she still play fetch?"

"She does." Entrapta rallies herself with shallow breath. "Scorpia, I would like to ask a favor of you." Her voice crackles like fresh snow crunching under a boot.

"Of course! Anything." I swing my pincer in front of me and clack it for emphasis.

"When I go back to Beast Island, could you keep Emily here?" She still won't look back over at me.

I pause. I've never seen her like this. How could she ask me to look after Emily? I mean, I will. There's no question that I will. But why? I never thought Entrapta would willingly leave Emily's side. "Of course, no doubt! But won't she miss you?"

"Oh, yes. It will take time for her cognitive logical processes to recover, but I'm afraid she is a little disruptive of Hordak's—I mean *our* work." She bites her lip. Somehow her pigtails dangle even more limply.

"Oh, I'm so sorry to hear that." A weight falls in my stomach. It pulls me in like a gravity something or other towards a sadness that effuses all around her. This must be what Catra meant. "Why don't you stay so she doesn't have to miss you so much? I mean, are you sure you want to go back to Beast Island? Not just for her, but all of us. We've all missed you here, Entrapta. You could stay a little longer."

"Hordak and I—I had to leave in the middle of an important project. He needs me back as soon as I can manage." Her voice is dry, as distant as her thoughts.

I raise a pincer to my chin. “Well… you know… Hordak can come, too. I haven’t seen the big lug since the Heart! How’s he been since She-Ra zapped Horde Prime outta him?”

She smirks sardonically. “Oh, he wouldn’t come. There’s just… he’s really focused right now. It would be nice to bring him, though. I think he’d like the infinite vacuum of space. But maybe he’s been there too much. It doesn’t matter. I need to get back soon.” She sets her data terminal beside her. The midday light catches in the shining blue eyes of her mask and casts two bright dots on her forehead. In place of her terminal, she interlocks her fingers and rests her hands on her lap. Her legs still kick over the side.

“I know he’s doing that whole… ‘making up for what did’ thing by cleaning up Beast Island, but you guys can take a break for this right? Come to think of it, how is that making up for anything? I mean, I guess bots have feelings too and there were some scary things on there but…” Her kicking has stopped, her body rigid. Something about what I said is too disruptive. I don’t want to hurt her. “He doesn’t have to come if he doesn’t want to. But I still think *you* should go. I think everyone could really use your help on Darla. What could be more important than bringing back the magic to the universe?”

She turns to me. Her expression shows a pain behind a stony veil.

It’s the first time that she’s looked at me and it’s like she’s a different person. Her eyes that normally sparkle with joy and energy are quiet and flat. Disconnected and disinterested in what was around her. This isn’t the Entrapta that I know.

I can’t dance around the subject anymore. Perfuma says that sometimes the best way to confront something was to face it head on.

“You know Darla won’t leave without you, right?”

She looks down and shakes her head. Her pigtails loosely follow the motion. "No, I should be able to convince her. Her operations are much more stable now that she's had time to mend her own systems."

"That probably doesn't matter much to her. She said you're the only person that she trusts to 'operate' on her. Her words, not mine." I emphasize my honesty with a pincer over my chest.

There's an almost fragile look in Entrapta's eyes when she turns to me again. "She did?"

"Well, yeah! Of course. Who else would she ask for?" I smile. Maybe that's headway?

She blinks and the brief glimpse of joy falls away. "That was very nice of her, but—"

Her mood is so delicate that it scares me a little. But I can be brave. "Catra asked for you, too."

Entrapta swallows. "I've ascertained that lots of individuals have been asking about me."

"Of course! We miss you. We've been completely lost with some of the tech we've recovered." I make a fumbling gesture with my pincers as though I could connect two wires together.

I catch a brief smile from her.

This feels right. I press further. "Maybe it's time to take a break from Beast Island. I think Hordak would be fine. And maybe… maybe there's some cool new tech out there or you can help people out in ways only you can. I mean, you saved us all from being chipped! Imagine what you could do when there *isn't* a crazy clone army trying to kill all of us."

She looks down, back towards the sea. "I did find those problems to be quite enjoyable to solve. I certainly didn't get to

work on anything like that on Etheria. But…" The brief brightness of enthusiasm in her fades. "I don't know…"

I bite my lip. "I think I know something else you could work on, too."

She pulls a pigtail forward and rests her chin on it. She plays with a small shell that rests on the dock, flipping it over and over with her heavy glove. "What's that?"

"Why not work on your friendships?"

She doesn't look up, only keeps worrying at the white fidget on the weathered wood. "I don't see the point of that scientific inquiry. They seem to be fine without me. I'm not sure what more data there is to gather there."

I scooch a little closer, using my tail for additional help. "That's not true! Think about it. You started with just me and Catra, and then you made friends with all the princesses. There are so many people out there in the universe, Entrapta. And I'm sure they'd all be happy to meet you and get to know you. You're one special gal."

"I believe in your earnestness, but I'm unclear if your data is biased or not. I don't think I am very good with friends." She sounds so far away like she was trying to talk with me from another kingdom.

"And you think I am?" I bump Entrapta with my elbow.

She is unmoved. She pokes the seashell again and the umbrella shaped object flips into the air, nearer to the edge of the dock. "Well, yeah. When I met you and Catra, you two already had an established social dynamic that you made me a part of. Of course you are capable of functional and enjoyable friendships."

"Ah." I remember when we found her in the vents. She just fell into our laps. The nicest and most reasonable prisoner we ever caught. "Funny thing about that. I didn't really know what being a

friend was, either." I spare a glance out to the water. "I don't think *anyone* knows how to be a friend right away. We all need to learn how to be one. Perfuma sure knows a lot. She always has good ideas about peace and calm. But I bet even *she* had to learn."

Entrapta stops poking at the shell and turns towards me. "I can't understand how the chlorokinesis princess would have difficulty with her social interactions. I don't know of any individuals that could dislike her. But your point has piqued a curiosity. Could you explain your logical derivations further?"

"Oh sure, you know… I mean when Catra… and she…" I push my claw forward and make a *zzzt* noise.

Entrapta stares at me. She nods, but doesn't say anything.

"Yeah, when she did that—after she did that, I kept trying to stick up for her. But I wanted to get you back, too. And I kind of… I screwed up, Entrapta. I was confused, and a little scared. So much was happening so fast and I didn't do anything." I lean back and prop myself up on both of my pincers. The sun sinks toward the horizon, casting a rufescent glow among the waves. "I let you down. And then I tried to make it better in the *worst* way possible. I thought I could convince Catra that she was wrong, but I was the wrong one. I figured it out later… too late. I was afraid. And I didn't stick up for you when I realized I should have."

"Oh, that's all right. Lots of things happened then." Her words are more natural. "The chaotic patterns of everyone's behaviors were very hard to discern in a logical way."

A tingling sweeps up my back and into my cheeks. "You make it sound simple."

"Well, it was. I wound up on Beast Island because I thought I could trust…" The thought dies in the wind of Seaworthy.

"See why I'm saying this friendship thing is hard? *I* screwed it up. And I had to learn from it. And I think it's kind of like you say. *Science is never wrong* . And having friends is kind of like a

science. Isn't it? Like you do things, little experiments, and you see how people react."

"Yes, but the data is so *unreliable* ." A small, exasperated emotion slips into her voice.

"Oh, tell me about it!" I smile and lean toward her. "But you know what's neat about it?"

"What's that?"

"I think it's the only science you can't do by yourself. You need people to look at the data with you and help you figure out what things mean. That's why I'm so glad I met Perfuma." The thought of her makes me smile and I turn back toward the sea. "So, maybe if you go on Darla, you can run some experiments with people up there. Friendship experiments. And get some new data. And maybe… maybe things will be better."

A tear drops from Entrapta's face. She doesn't bother covering it. She doesn't pull away. She sits there silently on the dock. I gently place a pincer behind her, and she leans into me.

"Okay," her voice cracks. "I think running some new experiments might be good for me."

"Great." I give her a small squeeze. "Why don't you report back to me with the results, huh? I can be your science buddy on this one."

"I'd like that." Her words are so tiny.

Melog ends their silent vigil behind us and finally trots alongside. They curl up next to Entrapta and she reaches out a hand to stroke their fur.

"Hey, I'm sorry, by the way."

"For what?" Her weight is miniscule against my pincer. Her pigtails wrap around it where the point meets the dock.

“For the whole Beast Island and Portal mess and not coming to get you sooner. I just wanted to say that.”

She scratches Melog behind their ears and they yawn. She doesn’t look at me, but pats my shoulder with one of her pigtails.

“I forgive you.” Her voice is hollow, but behind it I hear a little spark of hope. Something washed away with the waves of Seaworthy, and I know she's going to be all right. No matter what happens.

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